

Gonzalo Contreras Aguirre

Universidad Diego Portales
Escuela de Ciencia Política
Ejército 333
Santiago, Chile.

✉ gonzalo.contrerasa@mail.udp.cl
🎓 Google Scholar
🌐 Personal website

Appointments

Assistant Professor (2026 –).
Escuela de Ciencia Política.
Universidad Diego Portales, Chile.

Postdoctoral Fellow (2024–2026).
Center for Inter-American Policy & Research.
Tulane University, USA.

Education

University of Oxford
DPhil in Politics, 2024.
Advisors: Ezequiel González-Ocantos and Timothy Power.
Committee: David Doyle and Mathias Poertner.
Dissertation: “Clientelistic Dynamics in Programmatic Settings. Evidence From Chile.”
Awarded the 2023–24 Department of Politics and International Relations Prize for the Best Doctoral Thesis in Politics.

University of Oxford
MSc in Politics Research.

Universidad Diego Portales
B.A. in Political Science.

Peer-Reviewed Articles

Contreras, G. 2025. “Outsourcing Machines. How programmatic parties include clientelistic strategies.” *Comparative Political Studies*. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00104140241271310>.

* Awarded Best Article in the *Latin American Political Institutions Section (LAPIS)*, LASA 2025.

* Awarded Best Article in the *Subnational Politics & Society* section, LASA 2025.

Contreras, G. & M. Morales. 2026. “The Return to Compulsory Voting: Invalid Voting and its Representational Challenges in Chile’s Subnational Elections.” *Political Studies*. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00323217261460721>.

Contreras, G. 2026. “Clientelism Without Machines. The Use of Community-Based Groups as Organisational Substitutes.” *Latin American Politics and Society*. <https://doi.org/10.1017/lap.2026.10066>.

Contreras, G. and M. Morales. 2024. “Masking turnout inequality. Invalid voting and class bias when compulsory voting is reinstated.” *Electoral Studies*, Volume 92 (2024), 102878. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.electstud.2024.102878>

Belmar, F., G. Contreras, M. Morales and C. Troncoso. 2024. “Demanding Non-Programmatic Distribution: Evidence From Local Governments in Chile.” *Policy Studies*, 45(1), 65–88. <https://doi.org/10.1080/01442872.2023.2172718>

Contreras, G. and M. Morales. 2018. "Ethnic solidarity and the vote: Mapuche candidates and voters in Chile." *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies*, 44(11), 1954–1975. <https://doi.org/10.1080/1369183X.2017.1371582>

Contreras, G., A. Joignant and M. Morales. 2015. "The return of censitary suffrage? The effects of automatic voter registration and voluntary voting in Chile." *Democratization*, 22(1): 1–25. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13510347.2014.986720>

Cantillana, C., G. Contreras, M. Morales, D. Oliva and L. Perelló. 2017. "The Malaise with Democratic Representation in Latin America." *Política y Gobierno*, 24(2): 245–274. https://www.scielo.org.mx/scielo.php?script=sci_arttext&pid=S1665-20372017000200245

Cantillana, C., G. Contreras and M. Morales. 2015. "Primary Elections and Personalization of Politics: The Case of Local Elections in Chile 2012." *Revista de Ciencia Política*, 35(2): 273–298. <https://doi.org/10.4067/S0718-090X2015000200002>

Contreras, G. and P. Navia. 2013. "Generational Differences in Electoral Participation in Chile, 1988–2010." *Revista de Ciencia Política*, 33(2): 419–441. <https://doi.org/10.4067/S0718-090X2013000200001>

Contreras, G. and M. Morales. 2017. "Why was the voluntary vote approved in Chile? Reasons and arguments that drove the reform." *Revista Chilena de Derecho y Ciencia Política*, 8(2): 1–37.

Contreras, G. and M. Morales. 2014. "Young people and electoral participation in Chile 1989–2013. Analyzing the effect of the voluntary vote." *Revista Latinoamericana de Ciencias Sociales, Niñez y Juventud*, 12(2): 597–615.

Contreras, G. and A. Varas. 2015. "Inconsistencia de estatus y conducta electoral en Chile." *Revista de Ciencias Sociales*, 34: 22–46.

Under Review

Contreras, G., M. Morales and F. Belmar. "Pathways of Claim-Making: Direct Appeals, Organisational Mediation, and Clientelism." *Under review*. Article available upon request.

Contreras, G. & M. Morales. "Democracy, Political Mobilisation and Invalid Votes: New Evidence from Latin America, 1980–2025." *Under review*. Article available upon request.

Contreras, G. & P. Navia. "Targeting Beyond Class: Civic Participation and Vote-Buying in Chile" *Under review*. Article available upon request.

Contreras, G. & M. Morales. "The Pragmatic Citizen: Claim-Making on the Local State Regardless of Who Governs". *Under review*. Article available upon request.

Book Projects

Contreras, G. "Shaping Politics From Below. Claim-Making and the Clientelistic Turn of Programmatic Politics." *Book manuscript in preparation*.

Contreras, G., J. Lechartre & E. Aguirre. "From Local Voices to Theory Refinement. Crafting Local Research in Latin America." *Book manuscript in preparation*.

Working Papers

Contreras, G. "The Civic Basis of Vote-Buying: Evidence from Latin America and Africa". Article available upon request.

Contreras, G., J. Lechartre & J. Pérez Sandoval. “Challenges and Practicalities of Research Designs in Subnational Research.” Working paper presented at MPSA, April 2025.

Contreras, G. & N. De La Cerda. “A Model of Clientelistic Propensity: How Short-Term Economic Shocks Shape Voters’ Receptivity to Clientelism.” Working paper presented at IPSA 2025 and APSA 2025.

Contreras, G. “Placebo Reasoning in Process Tracing.” Article available upon request.

Contreras, G. “Mixing the Qualitative Toolkit: The Integration of Interviews and Participant Observation in Process Tracing.” Article available upon request.

Contreras, G., O. Peña, P. Sosa & M. Arce. “Signalling Responsiveness Through Party Labels: Evidence from Peru.” Working paper presented at APSA 2026.

Teaching

2021 – 2024

University College London

Seminar Instructor. Introduction to Quantitative Methods. Social Research Institute, Faculty of Education and Society (IOE). *Fall 2023*.

Seminar Instructor. Impact Evaluation Methods. Social Research Institute, Faculty of Education and Society (IOE). *Spring 2021 & 2022*.

Seminar Instructor. Regression Analysis. Social Research Institute, Faculty of Education and Society (IOE). *Fall 2021 & 2022*.

Post Graduate Teaching Assistant. Principles of Social Science Research. Department of Political Science. *Fall 2021*.

Post Graduate Teaching Assistant. Introduction to Quantitative Research Methods. Department of Political Science. *Fall 2022*.

Research Assistant for the Institute’s Methodological Innovation. Social Research Institute, Faculty of Education and Society (IOE).

2016–2017

Universidad Diego Portales

Lecturer at the Department of Communication and Literature. Course: “Institutions and Political Process in Chile”.

2011–2014

Universidad Diego Portales

Instructor in the Department of Political Science, teaching modules: “Methods & Epistemology”, “Qualitative Methods”, “Advanced Qualitative Methods in Political Science”, “Discourse Analysis”, “Comparative Politics Workshop” and “Research Design in Social Sciences”.

Conferences

05/2026. LASA 2026 Congress: Republic & Revolution. Paris, France.

09/2025. APSA Annual Meeting & Exhibition 2025. Vancouver, Canada.

07/2025. 28th IPSA World Congress of Political Science. Seoul, South Korea.

04/2025. 82nd Annual MPSA Conference. Chicago, USA.

05/2025. LASA 2025 Congress: Poner el cuerpo en Latinx América. San Francisco, USA.

01/2025. SPSA Annual Conference. San Juan, Puerto Rico.

09/2024. APSA Annual Meeting & Exhibition. “Democracy: Retrenchment, Renovation, & Reimagination.” Philadelphia, USA.

08/2024. ECPR General Conference. University College Dublin. Dublin, Ireland.

06/2024. LASA Conference. “Reaction and Resistance: Imagining Possible Futures in the Americas.” Bogotá, Colombia.

08/2023. APSA Annual Meeting & Exhibition. “Rights and Responsibilities in an Age of Mis- and Disinformation.” Los Angeles, USA.

05/2023. LASA Conference. “América Latina y el Caribe: Pensar, Representar y Luchar por los Derechos.” Vancouver, Canada.

06/2022. The 10th CEISAL International Conference: Uncertain Trajectories: Latin America After Globalization. Helsinki, Finland.

06/2014. VI Congreso Latinoamericano de Opinión Pública WAPOR, Santiago, Chile.

09/2013. VII Congreso de la Asociación Latinoamericana de Ciencia Política, Bogotá, Colombia.

06/2012. VI Congreso de la Asociación Latinoamericana de Ciencia Política, Quito, Ecuador.

11/2011. IX Congreso Latinoamericano de Estudios del Discurso, Universidade Federal de Minas Gerais, Belo Horizonte, Brazil.

11/2011. 6tas Jornadas de Jóvenes Investigadores, Universidad de Buenos Aires, Argentina.

11/2010. IX Congreso Chileno de Ciencia Política.

Past Appointments

2021 – 2024

University College London

Social Research Institute and Department of Political Science, Faculty of Education and Society (IOE). Seminar Instructor and PGTA for Quantitative Modules.

2020 – 2021

University of Oxford

Centre for Experimental Social Science (CESS), Nuffield College.

Research Assistant, administration of CESS events, and coordination of experiments agenda.

2011 – 2014

Universidad Diego Portales

Researcher and coordinator of research projects. Department of Political Science, Universidad Diego Portales, Santiago, Chile.

Administration of academic research projects at the Centre of Politics and Elections (OBPE), Universidad Diego Portales, Santiago, Chile.

Awards and Fellowships

[20] Best Doctoral Thesis in Politics 2023–24, awarded by the Department of Politics and International Relations, University of Oxford. <https://www.politics.ox.ac.uk/news/dpir-dphil-students-awarded-outstanding-thesis-prizes>.

[19] Celebrating 25 years Department of Political Science & International Relations. Gonzalo Contreras Alumni story. <https://www.politics.ox.ac.uk/read-gonzalos-story>.

[18] Excellence in Student Feedback Award. University College London, Department of Political Science, 2024.

[17] APSA First Generation Scholars in the Profession Annual Meeting Travel and Accessibility Grant. Awarded by the Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion Programs of the American Political Science Association.

[16] Virginia Gray Graduate Student Research Award, APSA Annual Conference 2023, Los Angeles, USA, in the Political Organizations and Parties section, 2023.

[15] APSA Organized Section Support Grant, APSA Annual Conference 2023, Los Angeles, USA, in the Comparative Politics section, 2023.

- [14] APSA Graduate Student Member Support Grant. APSA Committee on the Status of Graduate Students in the Profession.
- [13] Grant to attend ECPR General Conference 2024, provided by the Center for Inter-American Policy and Research (CIPR), Tulane University.
- [12] Grant to attend APSA Annual Meeting & Exhibition “Democracy: Retrenchment, Renovation, & Reimagination”, Philadelphia, USA. Provided by the Center for Inter-American Policy and Research (CIPR), Tulane University.
- [11] Postdoctoral Fellow Travel Fund, Fall 2025. Office of Graduate and Postdoctoral Studies (OGPS), Tulane University.
- [10] Postdoctoral Fellow Travel Fund, Fall 2024. Office of Graduate and Postdoctoral Studies (OGPS), Tulane University.
- [9] Travel Grant funded by Ms Julia Poschinger-Bray, St. Hugh’s College alumna, University of Oxford. Grant to attend APSA Annual Meeting 2023.
- [8] Vacation Course and Travel Grant. St. Hugh’s College, University of Oxford. Grant to conduct fieldwork in Santiago, Chile, 2021.
- [7] Barbinder Watson Travel Fund. St. Hugh’s College, University of Oxford. Grant to conduct fieldwork in Santiago, Chile, 2021.
- [6] Marco Villani Graduate Research Grant Fund. St. Hugh’s College, University of Oxford. Travel grant to participate at CEISAL conference, Helsinki, Finland, 2022.
- [5] Academic Expenses Grant. Worcester College, University of Oxford. Grant to conduct fieldwork in Santiago, Chile, 2018.
- [4] Becas Chile. Fully funded doctoral scholarship, 2019–2023.
- [3] Becas Chile. Fully funded postgraduate scholarship, 2018–2019.
- [2] First Class. B.A. Political Science. Awarded as the best student, cohort 2008. Department of Political Science, Universidad Diego Portales, 2012.
- [1] Merit Scholarship, Department of Political Science, Universidad Diego Portales, Chile, 2009.

Book Chapters

- Contreras, G. and M. Morales. 2017. “Elecciones presidenciales en Chile 2013. Voto voluntario y sesgo de clase”, en *El Tsunami Electoral de 2013 en Chile*, eds. C. Garrido, M. Morales and P. Navia, 41–62. Santiago: RIL Editores.
- Contreras, G., M. Morales and P. Navia. 2017. “Primarias presidenciales de 2013 en Chile: participación y resultados electorales”, en *El Tsunami Electoral de 2013 en Chile*, eds. C. Garrido, M. Morales and P. Navia, 63–84. Santiago: RIL Editores.
- Contreras, G. and M. Morales. 2015. “El sesgo de clase existió y existe. Análisis de la participación electoral en Chile (Municipales 2012 y Presidenciales 2013)”, en *Condicionantes de la Participación Electoral en Chile*, 79–114. Santiago: PNUD.
- Contreras, G., A. Espinoza and L. Perelló. 2012. “El Partido Comunista de Chile en las elecciones municipales: 1992–2008”, en *Democracia Municipal en Chile 1992–2012*, eds. M. Morales and P. Navia, 219–240. Santiago: Ediciones Universidad Diego Portales.

Contreras, G., F. González, M. Morales and D. Oliva. 2012. “Nuevo régimen electoral en Chile. Inscripción automática y voto voluntario”, en *Democracia Municipal en Chile 1992–2012*, eds. M. Morales and P. Navia, 65–94. Santiago: Ediciones Universidad Diego Portales.

Contreras, G., A. Madera and J. Torres. 2012. “La coordinación partidaria en Chile: análisis de los subpactos de la Concertación en las elecciones municipales 1992–2008”, en *Democracia Municipal en Chile 1992–2012*, eds. M. Morales and P. Navia, 285–306. Santiago: Ediciones Universidad Diego Portales.

Contreras, G. 2010. “La Concertación de Partidos por la Democracia en Chile. Razones de su éxito y factores de su derrota”, en *El sismo electoral de 2009: Cambio y continuidad en las preferencias políticas de los chilenos*, eds. M. Morales and P. Navia, 145–164. Santiago: Ediciones Universidad Diego Portales.

Languages and Skills

English (advanced), Spanish (native).
R, Stata, L^AT_EX, Markdown, NVivo, ATLAS.ti.

Professional Experience 2014 – 2018

Ministry of Interior, Government of Chile

Senior Adviser. Home Office. Santiago, Chile.

Professional adviser on institutional reforms and political analysis for the Chilean Government.

Professional Activities

Reviewer: *Comparative Political Studies*, *Journal of Politics*, *British Journal of Political Science*, *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies*, *Democratization*, *Party Politics*, *Electoral Studies*, *Latin American Research Review*, *Revista de Ciencia Política*, *Latin American Journal of Social Sciences*, *IETE Journal of Education*.

Member of APSA and the APSA Section Political Organizations and Parties; Latin American Studies Association (LASA); European Consortium for Political Research (ECPR) and the Southern Political Science Association (SPSA).

Invited Talks

Núcleo Milenio para el Estudio de la Política, Opinión Pública y Medios en Chile. Seminario Núcleo MEPOP. Presentation of the paper “A Model of Clientelistic Propensity: How Short-Term Economic Shocks Shape Voters’ Receptivity to Clientelism.” October 2025.

Instituto de Ciências Sociais, Universidade de Lisboa. Presentation of the paper “Pathways of Claim-Making: Direct Appeals, Organisational Mediation, and Clientelism.” January 2026.

Department of Political Science, Tulane University. Talk on “The Politics of Representation and Party Politics.” October 2025.

Department of Politics and International Relations, University of Oxford. Roundtable talk: “Application for Postdoctoral Fellowships.” May 2024.

References

Ezequiel González-Ocantos
Nuffield College & DPIR
University of Oxford
ezequiel.gonzalez@politics.ox.ac.uk

David Doyle
Head of DPIR
University of Oxford
david.doyle@politics.ox.ac.uk